

Biblioteca

User Guide

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Introduction

What the program does

Biblioteca is the catalogue of your books on Android. It keeps the title, authors, subjects, year, country, where the copy is, whether it is on loan and your own notes — and shows all of it in a list you can search and filter.

It is the same catalogue as the Mac, Windows and iPhone apps: all four read and write the SAME file, biblioteca.txt. What you add on the phone shows up on the computer, and the other way round.

On the phone it has the camera: you can point it at the barcode on the back cover and the book is added for you, with title, authors and year looked up from the ISBN.

What it needs

A folder on your phone or in your cloud with a file called biblioteca.txt inside. That is what the app reads, and what it writes to.

You choose the folder once, under Sync, and the app remembers.

If you do not have that file yet, the app creates one: pick the folder and, if it is empty, it creates biblioteca.txt there and tells you. The chapter "The first time" shows the whole path.

Looking books up by ISBN and fetching covers from the internet need a connection. Everything else works offline.

What it produces

biblioteca.txt itself, updated on every change. It is a plain text file, one book per line with tab-separated fields — you can open it in any editor, and it does not depend on this app to be read.

The Countries screen also gives you a count of books by country of origin.

Covers you take with the camera are kept on the device itself. Covers are published into biblioteca.dat, for the other devices to see, by the Mac and iPhone apps.

Installing

There are two ways in, and both install exactly the same version. It works on Android 7 or newer.

From the Play Store (closed test)

Biblioteca is in a closed test. Without accepting the invitation the app does not show up in the store — and the invitation needs a Google account.

1. Accept the closed-test invitation with the same Google address you use on the phone.
2. Open the Play Store link that came with it and tap Install.
3. If you already have Biblioteca, tap Update. Your books and covers stay where they are.

From the .apk file

If your address is not a Google one, or the invitation does not open, install the file directly. It is the same version.

1. Download Biblioteca-Android.apk from https://ruggierow.github.io/biblioteca/. Chrome warns that this kind of file can be dangerous: tap "Download anyway".
2. Tap the downloaded file — from the notification, or in My Files › Downloads.
3. Android says it cannot install apps from unknown sources and offers a Settings button: tap it and allow. Go back and tap Install.
4. On newer Galaxy phones, Auto Blocker stops this BEFORE that and does not offer the shortcut. Go to Settings › Security and privacy › Auto Blocker and turn it off; then tap the file again.
5. Do not uninstall the old version first: it is updated in place and everything is preserved. Uninstalling first erases the covers kept on the device.

Checking that it worked

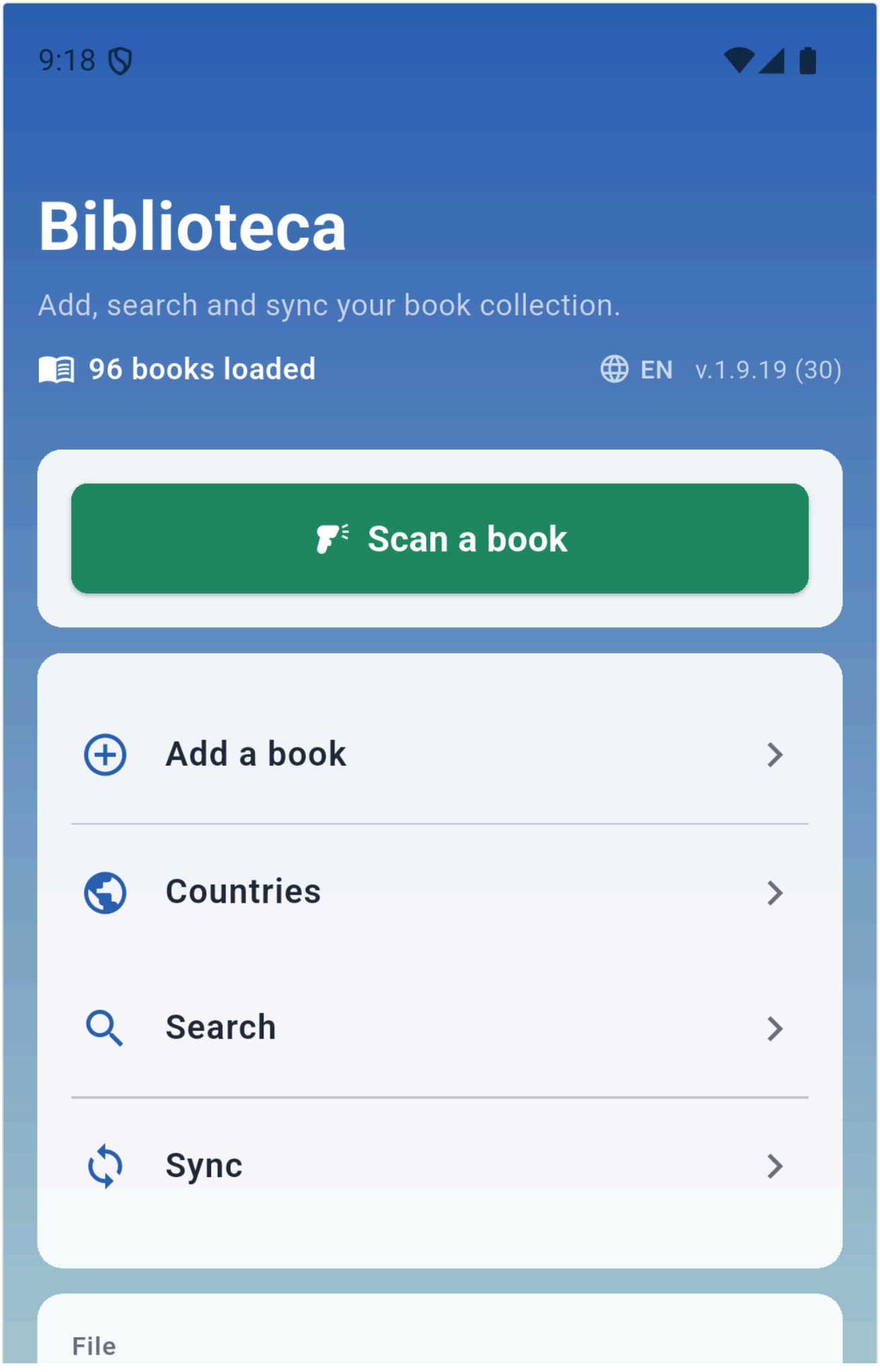
The app opens on the home screen, with the blue header, the name Biblioteca and, just below, how many books were loaded. The first time the number is zero and the "File" band at the bottom says "No file linked" — that is expected, and the next chapter sorts it out.

The home screen

It is the starting point for everything. The header shows how many books are loaded, the language and the version; below it, the app's five paths; and at the bottom, the "File" band, which says which file it is working with.

Step by step

1. "Scan a book" opens the camera to read the barcode on the back cover.
2. "Add a book" opens the form for a new book, to fill in by hand.
3. "Countries" shows where your books come from.
4. "Search" opens the whole list, with search and filters.
5. "Sync" is where you choose the folder and re-read the file.
6. To change the language, tap the "PT" or "EN" beside the globe, in the header, and choose.


9:18
Biblioteca
Add, search and sync your book collection.
96 books loaded
EN
v.1.9.19 (30)
Scan a book
Add a book
Countries
Search
Sync
File

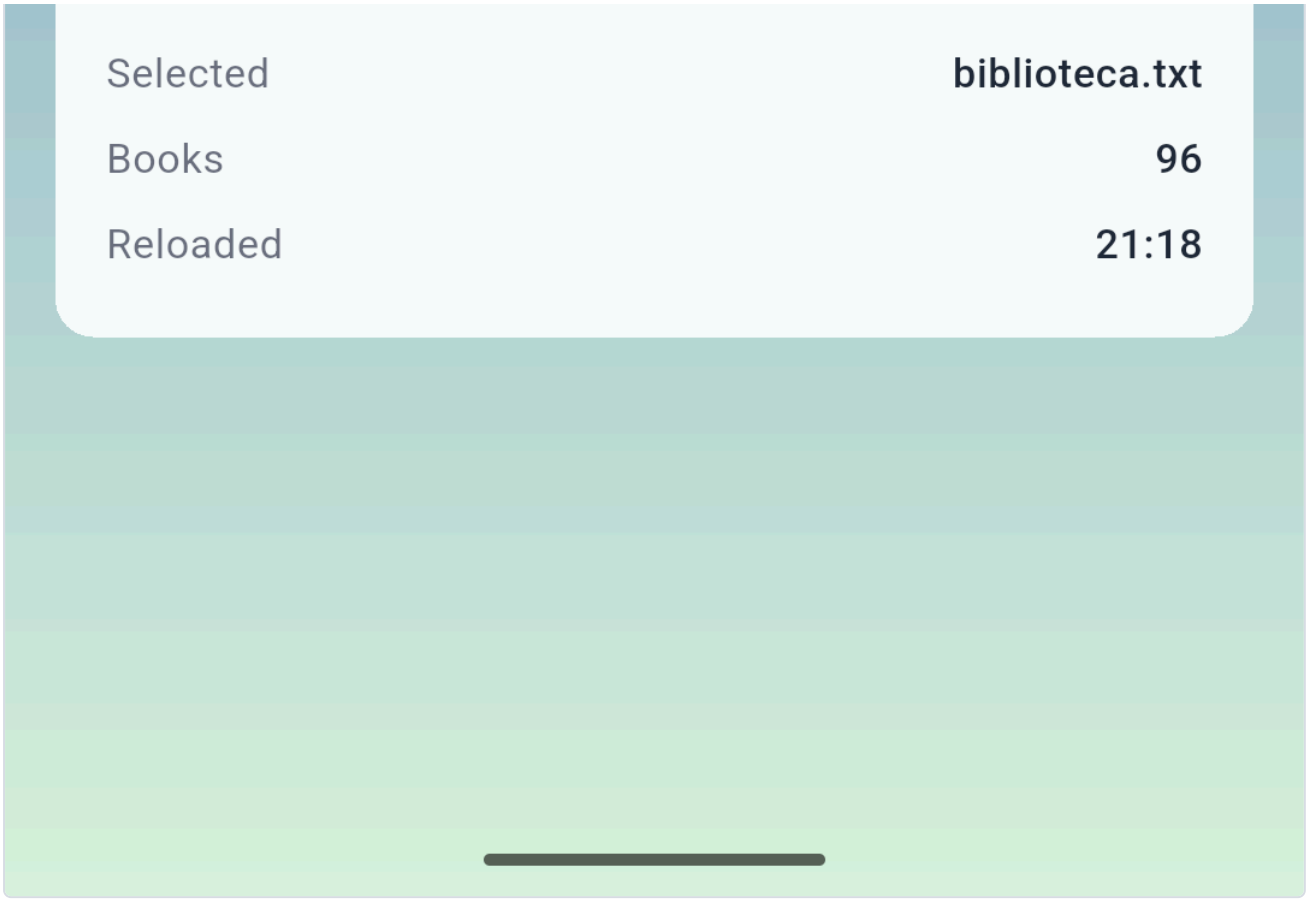


Figure 1: The home screen, with the five paths and the file band

Examples

- The number of books loaded is the quickest check there is: if it is zero when it should not be, the problem is the file, not your entries.
- The first time, the language follows the device. Once you pick one in the selector, your choice always wins.

The first time: choosing the folder

Your books live in a text file called `biblioteca.txt`. You do not have to create it anywhere: just tell the app which folder it is in — or which folder you want it to live in. That is what the "Choose folder" button does, and it is the same one on all four platforms.

It is a row on the home screen, just above Sync. While no folder has been picked it is the only thing you can do: Add a book, Countries and Search stay dimmed, because with no file there is nowhere to write the book.

Step by step

1. On the home screen, tap "Choose folder".
2. Android's picker opens. Go into a SUBFOLDER — Android refuses roots such as "My Drive" and the phone's own storage. Tap "USE THIS FOLDER" and then "ALLOW".
3. The app looks at the folder and tells you what it found. There are four possible answers, and in all of them you end up ready to add books.

What the app answers

The folder already had a library

It says how many books it found and asks whether that is the one. The count is there on purpose: accepting a file without knowing what is inside it would be a guess.

The folder was empty

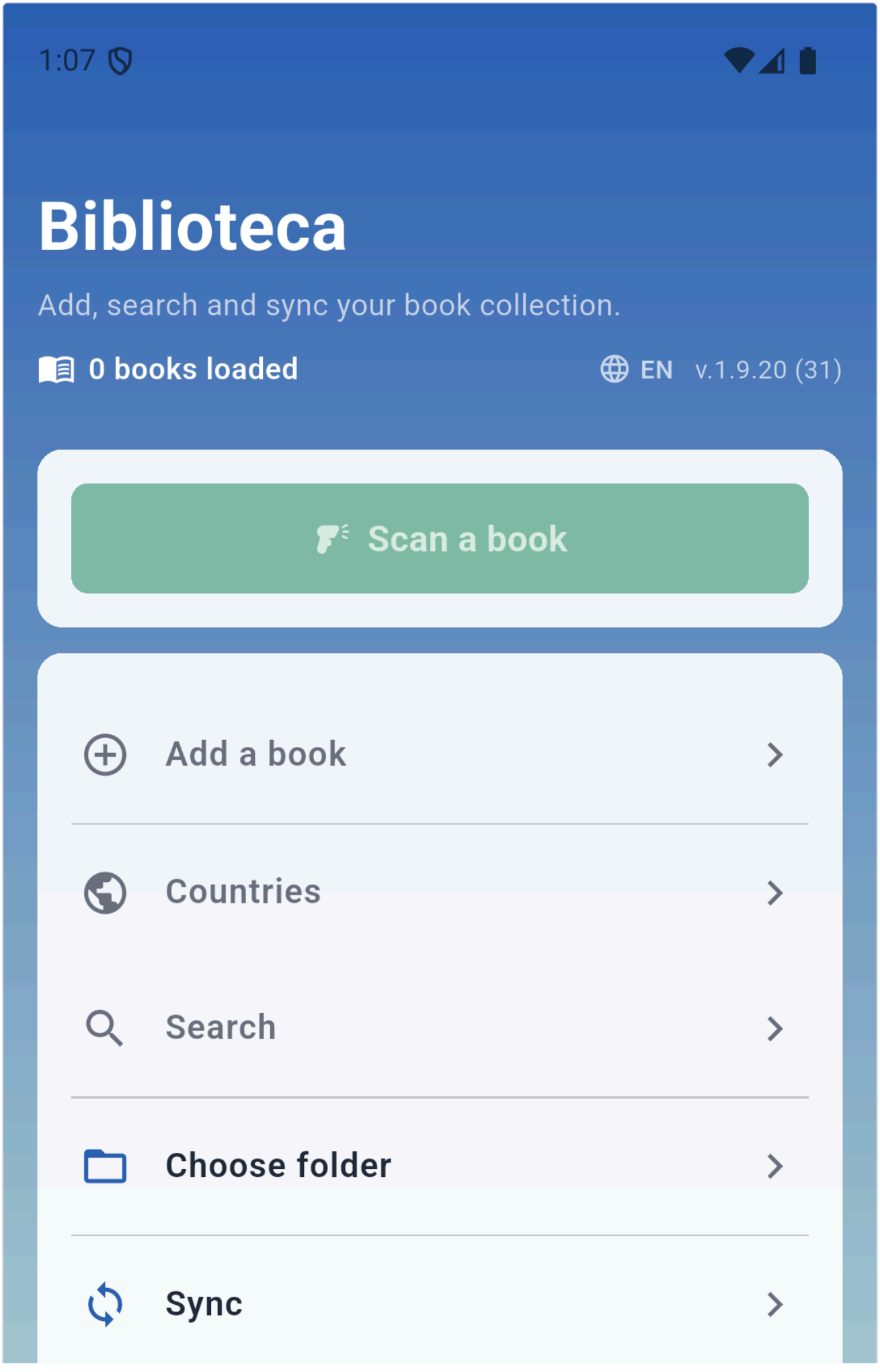
It creates biblioteca.txt there and tells you. It asks nothing — you have just picked that folder for exactly this.

There is a file and it could not be read

It says what happened and offers another folder. It never writes over it: that may be somebody's library, or a file still coming down from the cloud.

You changed folders with books already open

If the new folder is empty, it asks what to do with the books in view: move them there, or start a new, empty library. Either way, the library in the old folder is left untouched.


1:07
Biblioteca
Add, search and sync your book collection.
0 books loaded
EN
v.1.9.20 (31)
Scan a book
Add a book
Countries
Search
Choose folder
Sync

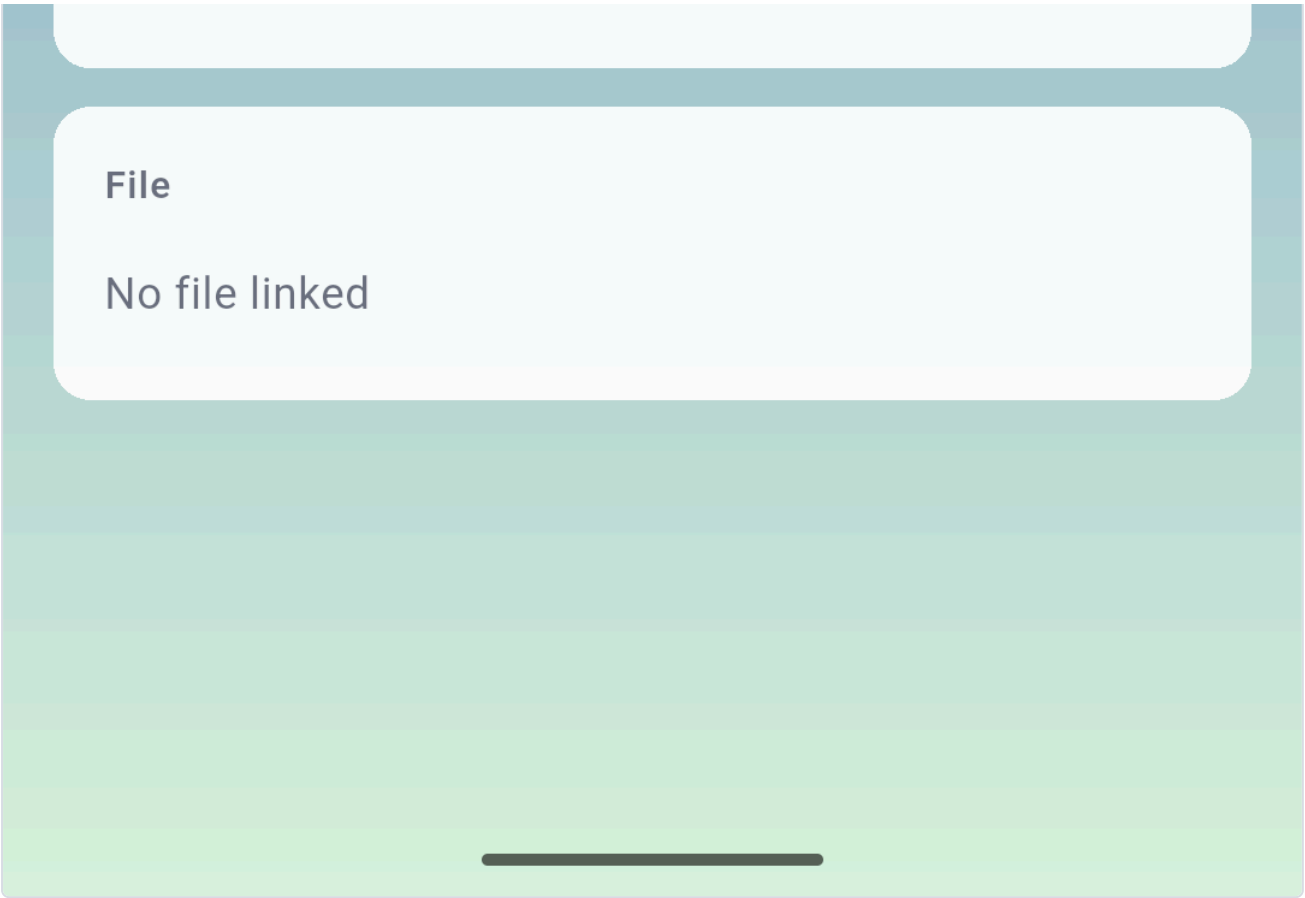


Figure 2: The home screen on the first run: only "Choose folder" responds

Examples

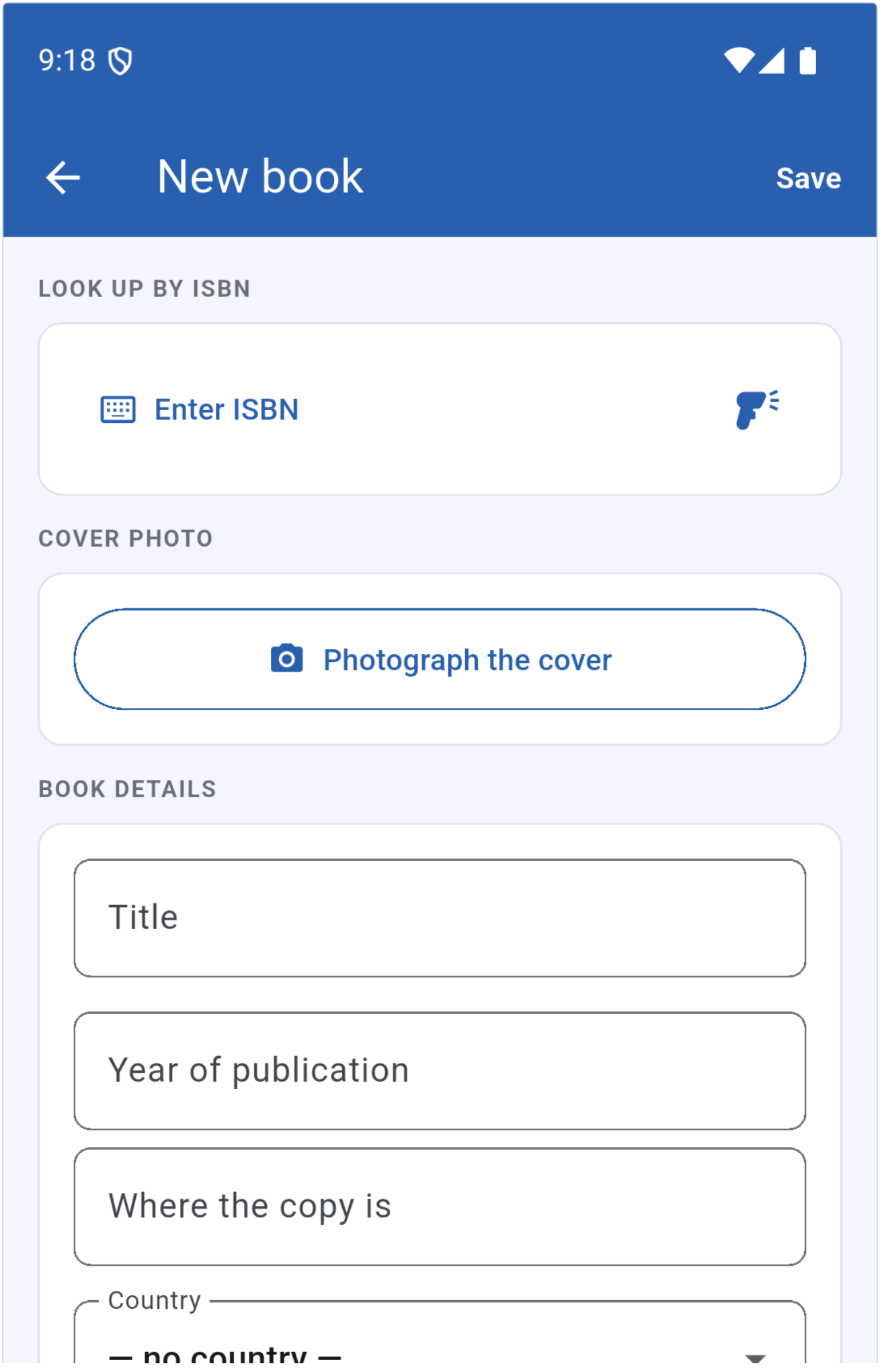
- Android refuses roots. "My Drive" and the internal storage come back with "Use this folder" dimmed and the warning "To protect your privacy, choose another folder". Go into a subfolder — inside Google Drive it works normally.
- Which folder to pick: if you use the app on more than one device, pick a cloud folder the computer can see too — a Google Drive subfolder, for instance. If you only use the phone, any folder will do.
- Changing folders later is the same button. It is not only for the first time.
- What about biblioteca.dat, the one with the covers? It is not born with it. It only comes into being once you have covers and publish them. Until then nothing is missing: the app works without it.

Adding a book

The form has three parts: the ISBN lookup at the top, the cover photo in the middle and the book's details below. The only required field is the title.

Step by step

1. Tap "Add a book" on the home screen.
2. If you have the ISBN, type it and tap the magnifier: title, authors and year come filled in.
3. Tap "Photograph the cover" to use the camera, if you want the cover.
4. Fill in the Title, the Year of publication and Where the copy is.
5. Tap "+ Add author" once per author and "+ Add subject" once per subject.
6. Scroll to the bottom for the Country, the Reading Group, the On loan state and the Notes.
7. Tap "Save", in the top right corner. The file is written at once.


9:18
New book
Save
LOOK UP BY ISBN
Enter ISBN
COVER PHOTO
Photograph the cover
BOOK DETAILS
Title
Year of publication
Where the copy is
Country
— no country —

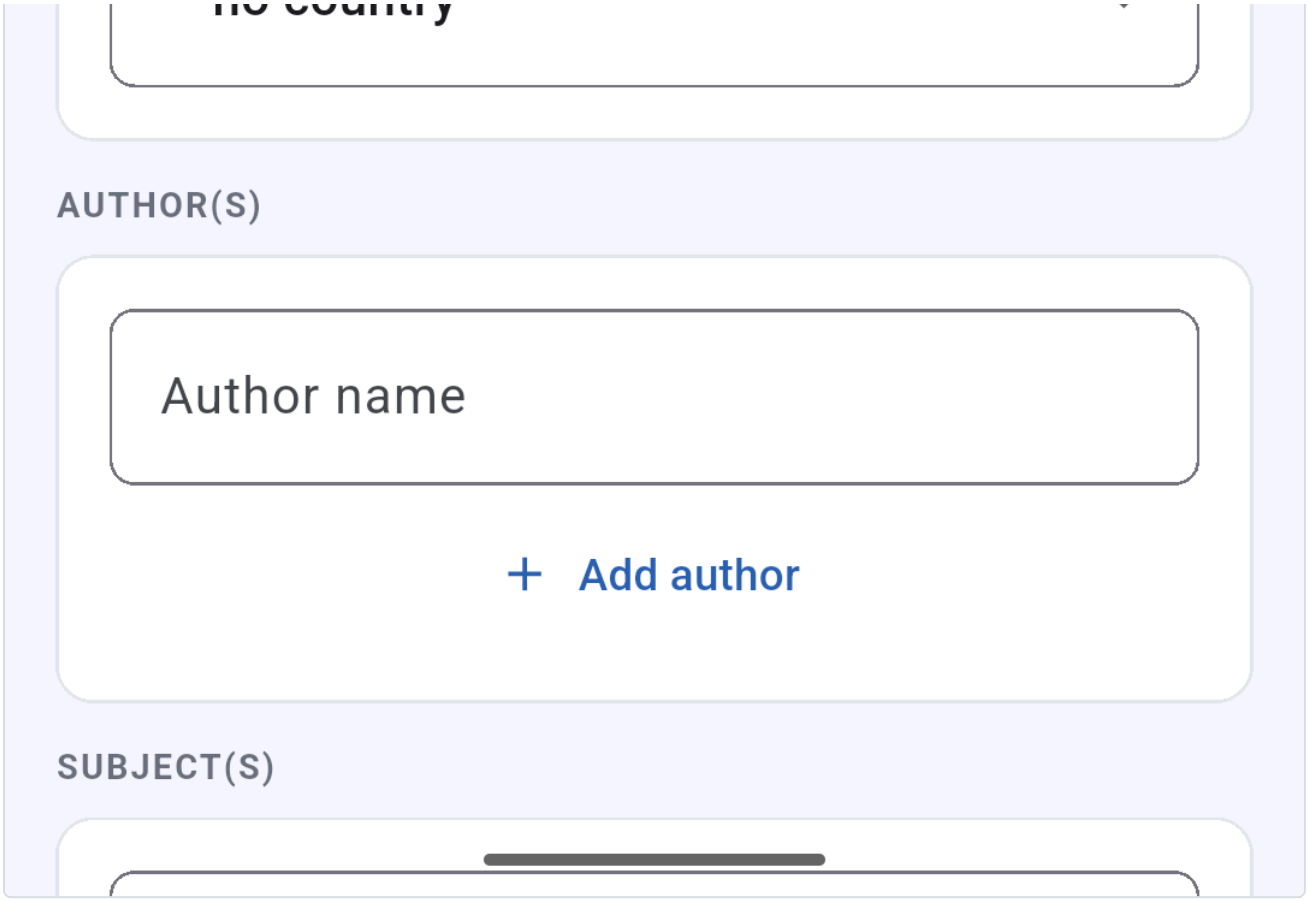
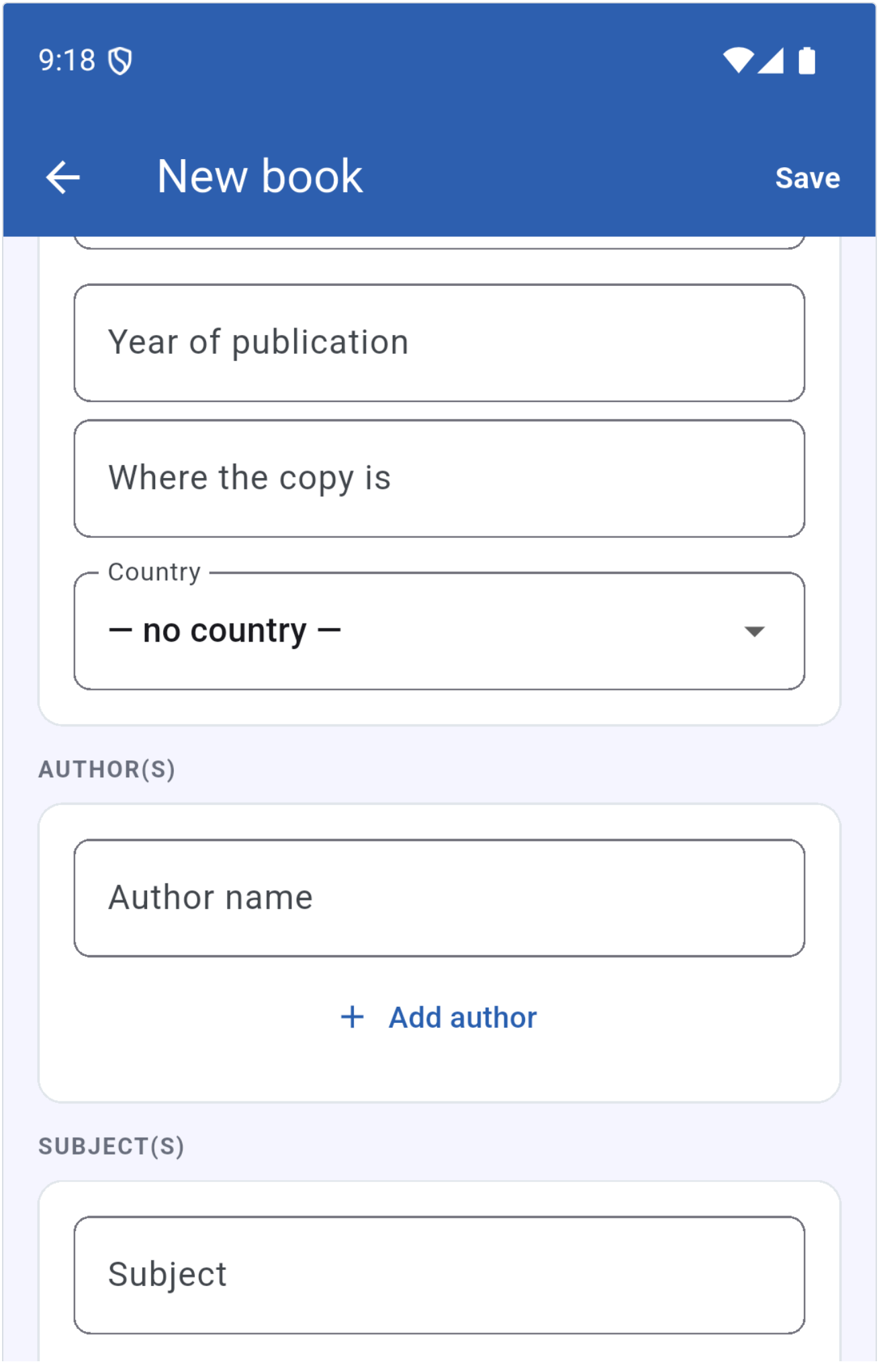


Figure 3: The top of the form: ISBN, cover photo and the first fields


9:18
New book
Save
Year of publication
Where the copy is
Country
— no country —
AUTHOR(S)
Author name
+ Add author
SUBJECT(S)
Subject

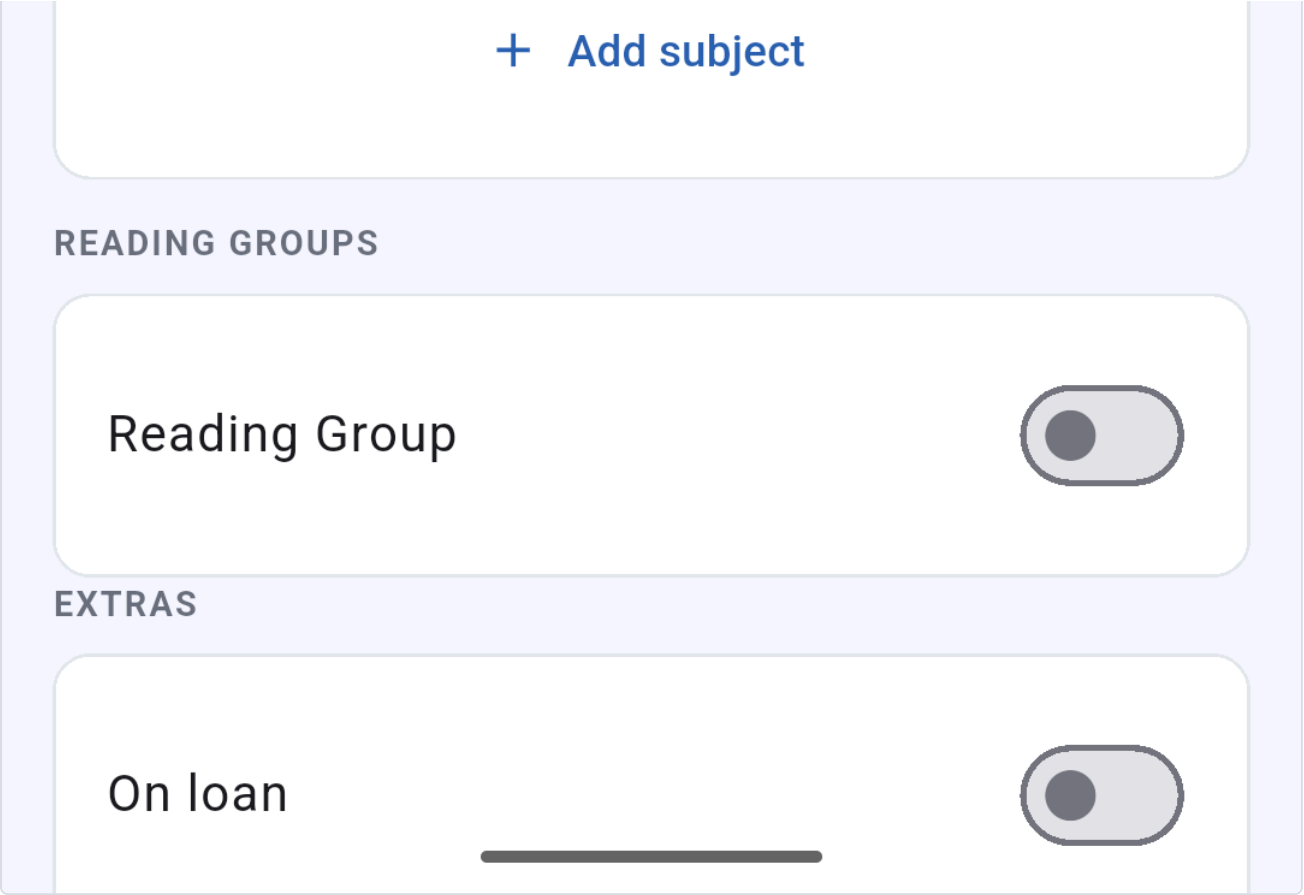


Figure 4: The rest of the form: authors, subjects, group and loan

Examples

- Scanning beats typing: from the home screen, "Scan a book" reads the barcode and opens the form already filled in.
- The camera is only asked for when you use the camera. If you deny the permission, all the rest of the app keeps working.

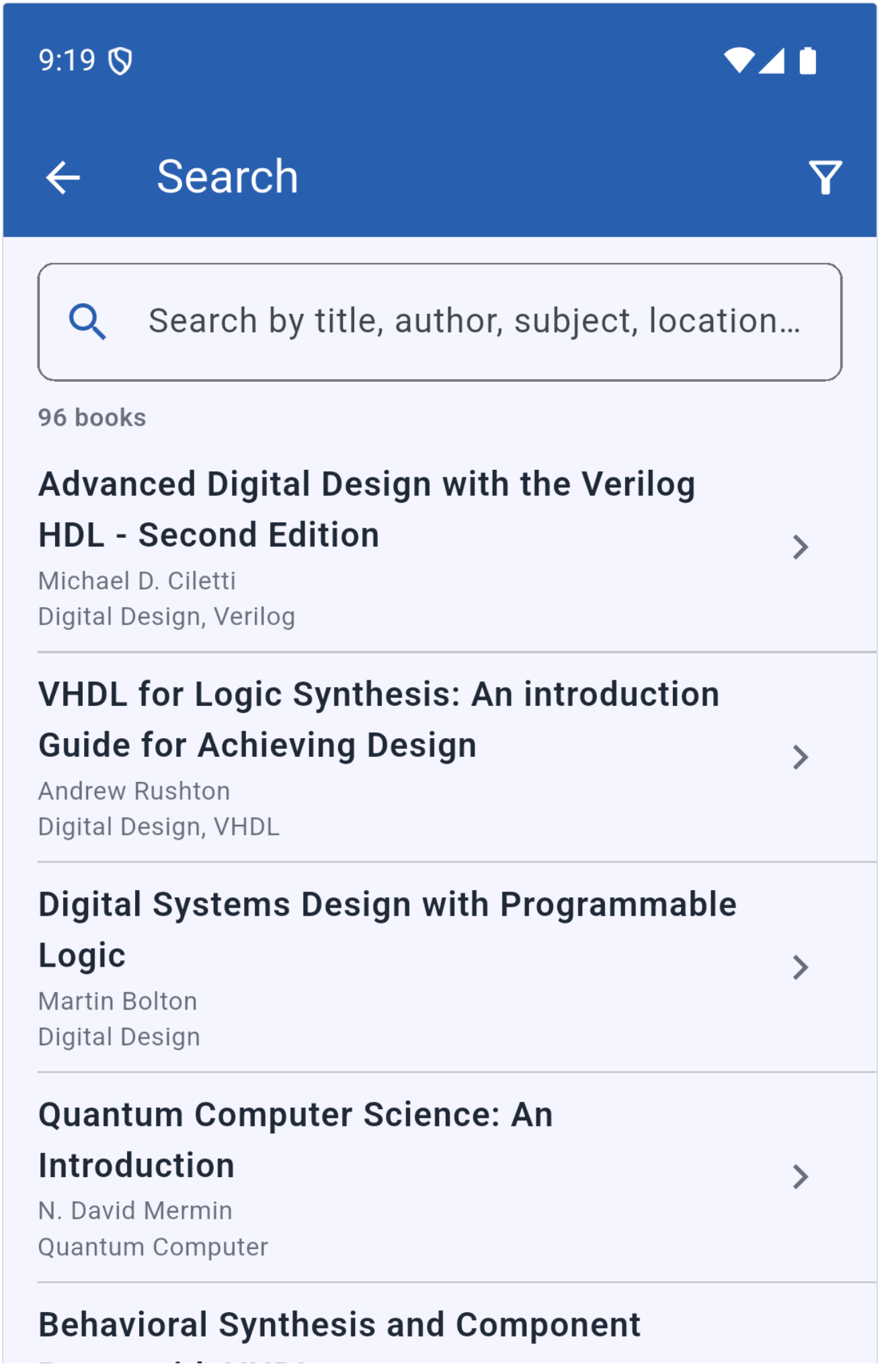
Search

It opens the whole list, with the count at the top. The search box looks in title, author, subject and location at the same time; the filter icon in the corner adds status, group and country.

Step by step

1. Tap "Search" on the home screen.
2. Type a piece of what you are looking for — it need not be the whole word, and case does not matter.

3. Tap the filter icon to narrow by status, reading group or country.
4. Tap a book to open its record.


9:19
Search
Search by title, author, subject, location…
96 books
Advanced Digital Design with the Verilog HDL - Second Edition
Michael D. Ciletti
Digital Design, Verilog
VHDL for Logic Synthesis: An introduction Guide for Achieving Design
Andrew Rushton
Digital Design, VHDL
Digital Systems Design with Programmable Logic
Martin Bolton
Digital Design
Quantum Computer Science: An Introduction
N. David Mermin
Quantum Computer
Behavioral Synthesis and Component

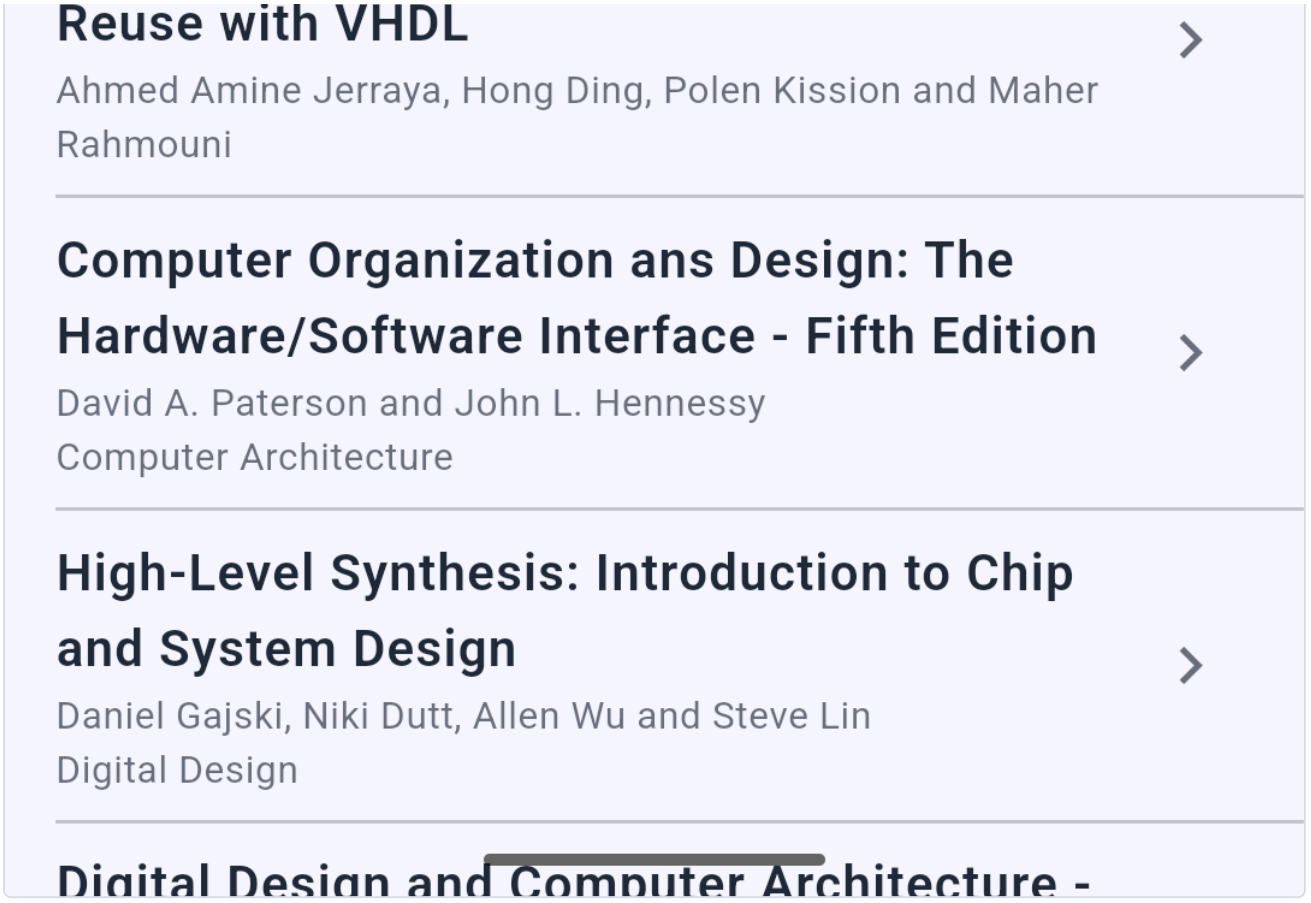


Figure 5: Search, with the count at the top and the list below

Examples

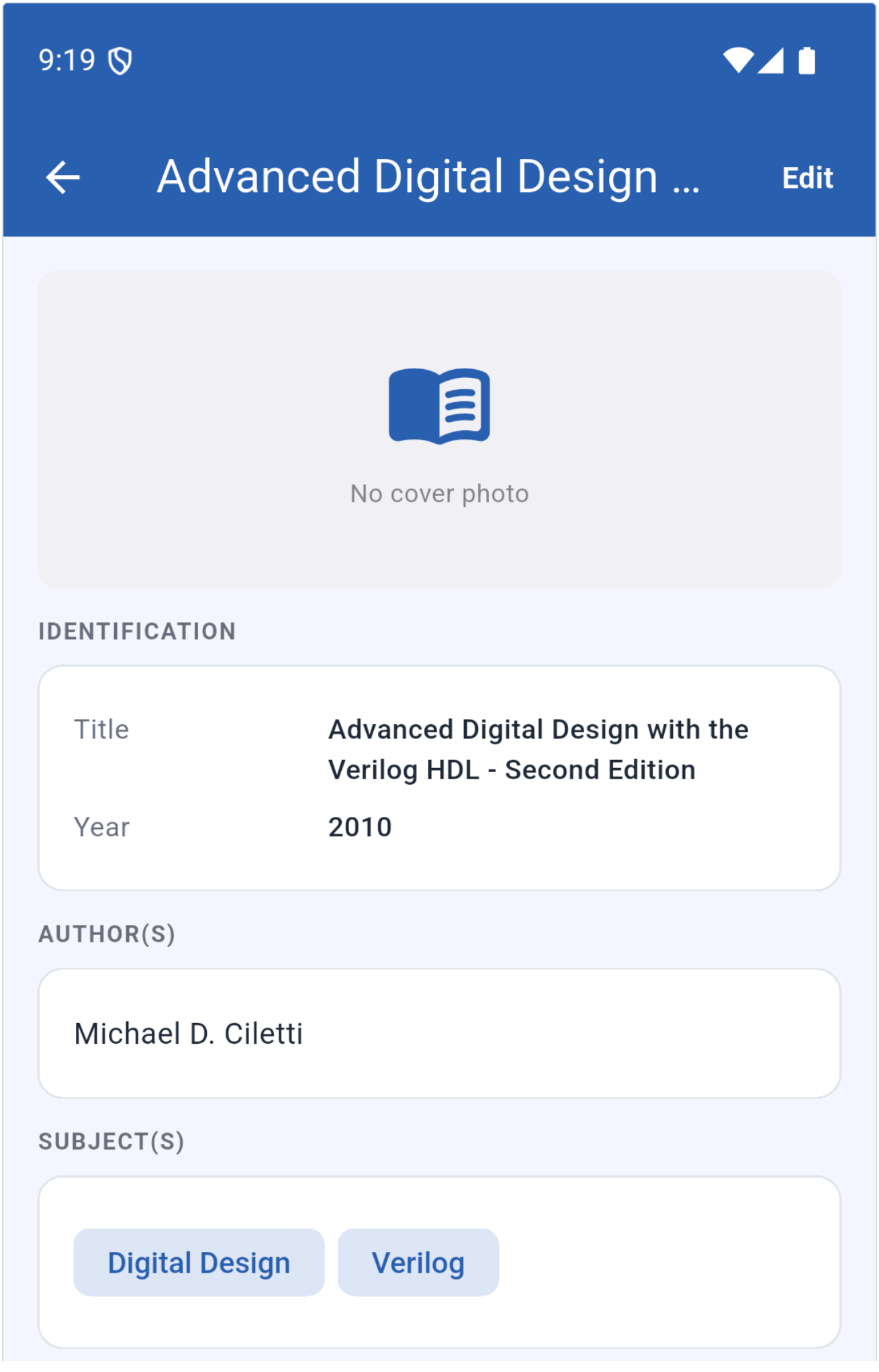
- The count at the top says how many books the current filter let through. It is how you check that the search did what you expected.
- Searching by location — "shelf 3" — is the quickest way to find a book at home.

The book's record

It shows everything kept about that book, in sections: the cover, the identification, the authors, the subjects, the status and your notes. The "Edit" button at the top opens the same form as adding, with the details filled in.

Step by step

1. In search, tap the book.
2. Scroll to see the subjects, the status and the notes.
3. Tap "Edit" to correct any field.


9:19
Advanced Digital Design ...
Edit
No cover photo
IDENTIFICATION
Title
Advanced Digital Design with the Verilog HDL - Second Edition
Year
2010
AUTHOR(S)
Michael D. Ciletti
SUBJECT(S)
Digital Design
Verilog

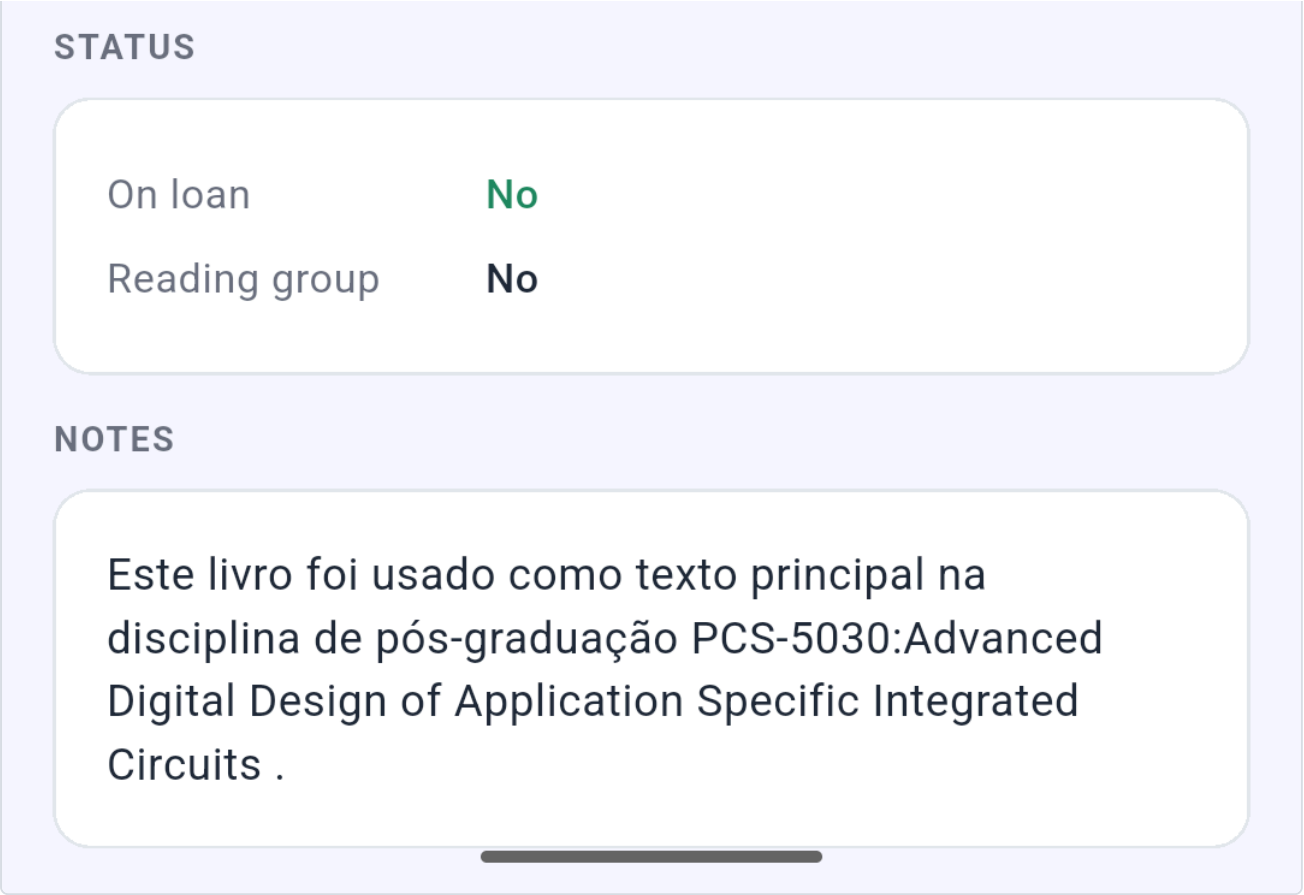


Figure 6: A book's record, with the cover and the sections

Examples

- Sections with nothing in them do not appear: a book with no subjects simply has no Subject(s) section, instead of showing an empty one.
- When a note has a web address in it, it becomes a link right there.

Countries

The count of books by country of origin, largest first, with a bar giving each one's share.

A book's country is where the literature comes from, not where the edition was printed.

Step by step

1. Tap "Countries" on the home screen.
2. The top line says how many books have a country and across how many countries they fall.


9:19
Countries
96 books from 6 countries
United States
29
Brazil
19
United Kingdom
19
France
10
Germany
10
Netherlands
9

Figure 7: The count by country, with the proportion bar

Examples

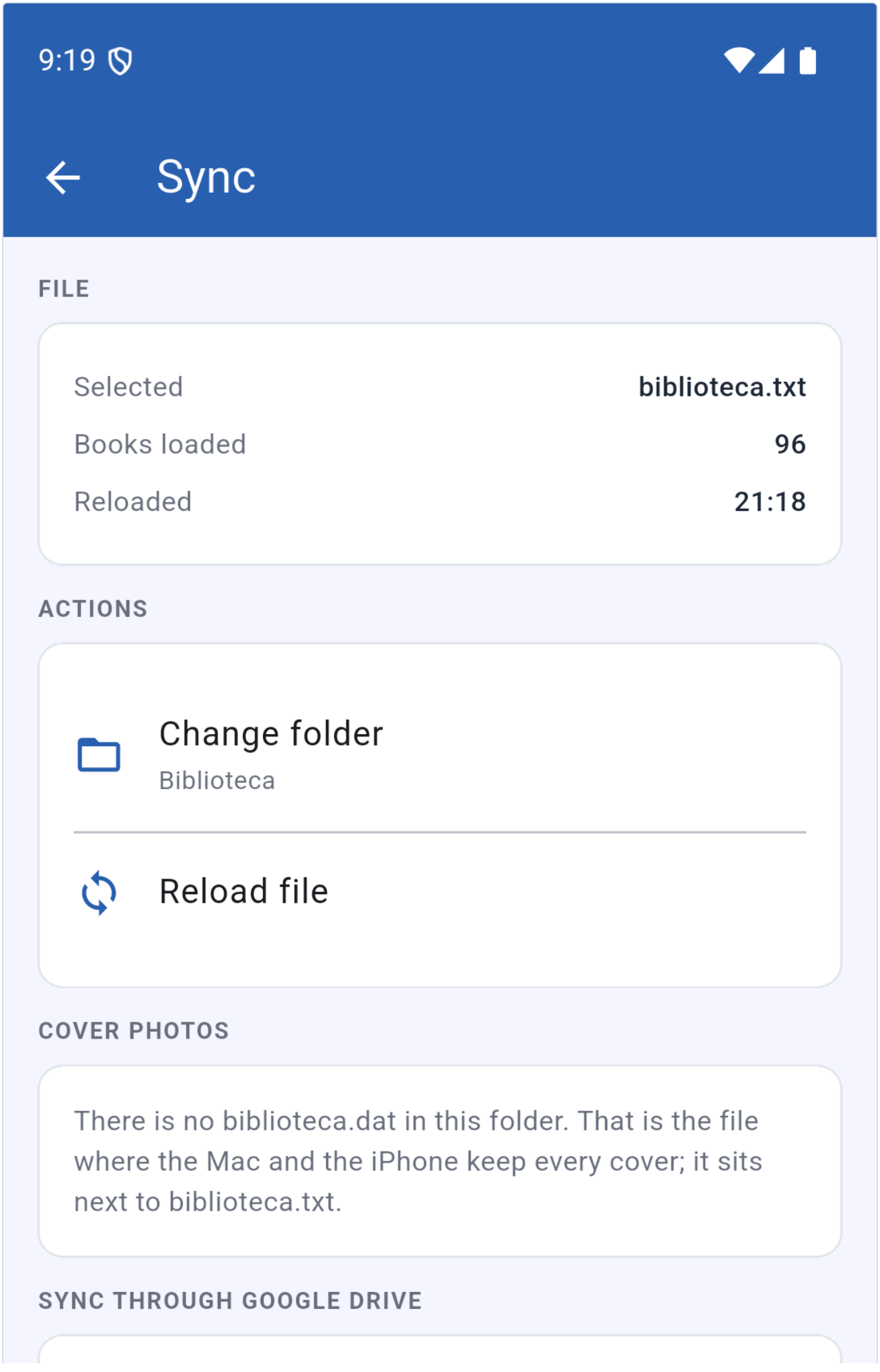
- The country is optional. Books with no country are left out of the count, and the screen says how many there are.
- To give a book a country, open its record, tap Edit and pick one in the Country field.

Sync

This is the file screen. It says which one is linked, how many books came from it and at what time; it offers to change folder and to reload; and at the bottom it explains how to make the phone and the computer see the same collection.

Step by step

1. "Change folder" picks another folder — and shows the current one's name below.
2. "Reload file" reads the file again. Use it after changing the library on another device.
3. The "Cover photos" section says whether there is a biblioteca.dat in the folder, and what it is.


9:19
Sync
FILE
Selected
biblioteca.txt
Books loaded
96
Reloaded
21:18
ACTIONS
Change folder
Biblioteca
Reload file
COVER PHOTOS
There is no biblioteca.dat in this folder. That is the file where the Mac and the iPhone keep every cover; it sits next to biblioteca.txt.
SYNC THROUGH GOOGLE DRIVE

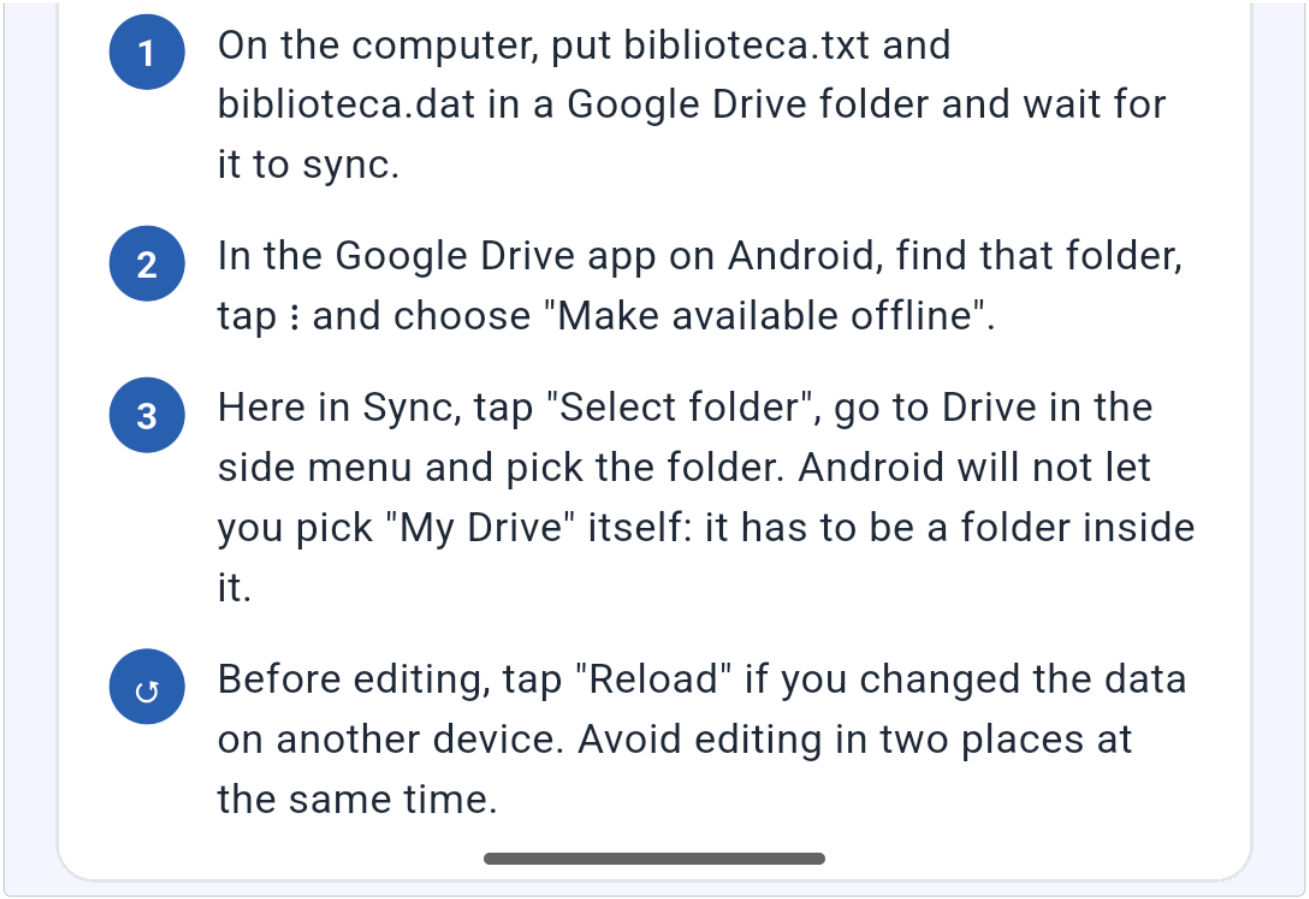


Figure 8: The Sync screen, with the file linked

Examples

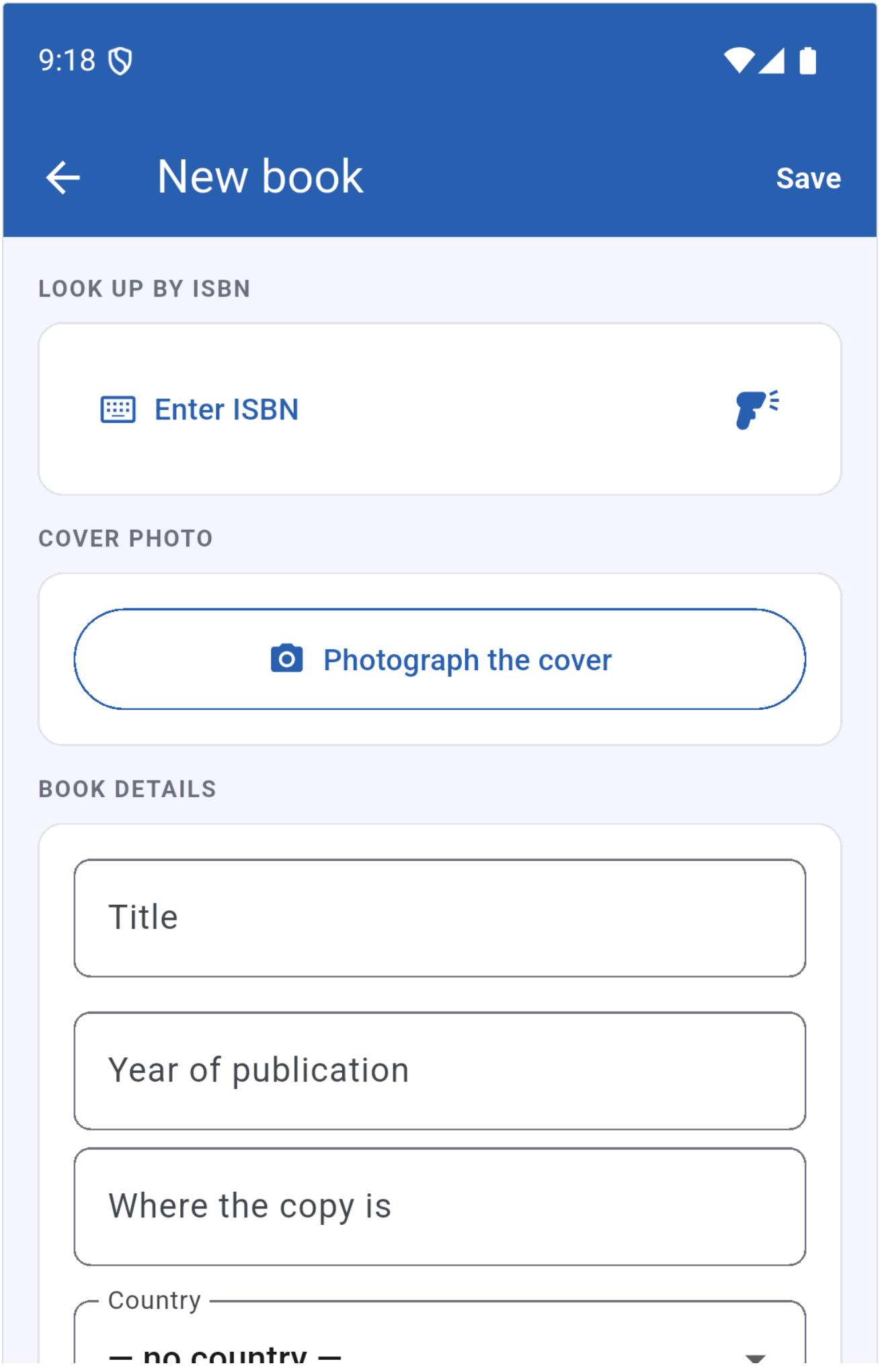
- There is no save button: every change is written at once. The "Saved" time in the file band is the proof of that.
- biblioteca.dat is where the Mac and the iPhone keep every cover. Android READS it to show the covers that came from there, but does not write to it: photos you take here stay on the device.
- Avoid editing the same library on two devices at the same time. Whoever writes last wins.

Tutorial: from nothing to your first book

This is the whole path for someone who has just installed the app and has no file at all. At the end of it you come out with the folder chosen, biblioteca.txt created and a book in it.

1. Open the app. It shows 0 books and "No file linked" — that is expected.
2. Tap "Choose folder", on the home screen itself.

3. In the picker, go into a subfolder — of Google Drive, if you want the computer to see it too. Tap "USE THIS FOLDER" and "ALLOW".
4. Since the folder is empty, the app creates biblioteca.txt there and tells you. The "File" band now shows the file's name.
5. Go back to the home screen and tap "Scan a book". Point the camera at the barcode on the back cover of a book you have at hand.
6. The form opens with title, authors and year filled in. Check them, write in Where the copy is where the book sits, and add a subject.
7. Tap "Photograph the cover" and take the photo.
8. Tap "Save". Go back to the home screen: the header now says 1 book loaded, and the file in the folder has one line.


9:18
New book
Save
LOOK UP BY ISBN
Enter ISBN
COVER PHOTO
Photograph the cover
BOOK DETAILS
Title
Year of publication
Where the copy is
Country
— no country —

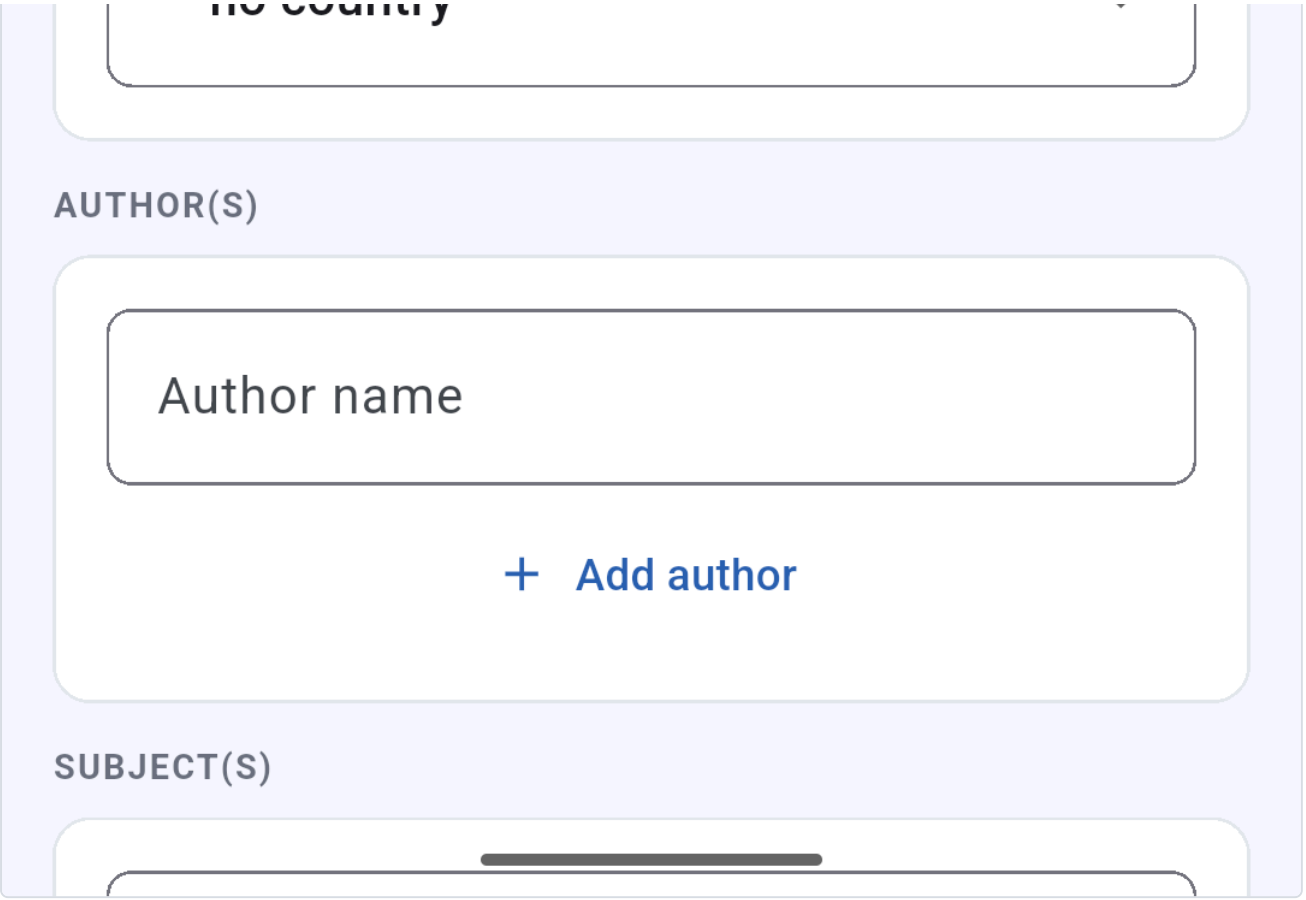


Figure 9: The form open, ready for the first book

Troubleshooting

I installed the app and I do not know how to create my biblioteca.txt.

On the home screen, tap "Choose folder" and pick a folder — it can be empty. If there is no biblioteca.txt inside, the app creates one there and tells you.

The picker will not let me choose "My Drive" or the phone's storage.

Android refuses roots to protect your privacy — the "Use this folder" button stays greyed out. Go into a subfolder and pick that. Inside Google Drive it works normally.

The app says "There is no biblioteca.txt in the folder".

Tap "Choose folder" again: if the right folder already has the file, the app says how many books it found and asks you to confirm; if the folder really is new, it creates the file there.

"Add a book" does not open.

There is no file linked, and with no file there is nowhere to write. Sort the folder out under Sync and Add a book works again.

I changed the library on the computer and the phone does not show it.

Tap "Reload file", under Sync. And check that the cloud has finished syncing on the computer's side — the app reads what is on the device.

The covers do not show, although they exist on the computer.

They come from biblioteca.dat, which must be in the SAME folder as biblioteca.txt. On the Mac or Windows, use "Export photos → iCloud Drive" to write it there, then reload here.

The ISBN lookup did not find the book.

That happens with old editions and small print runs. Type the title by hand: nothing else depends on the ISBN.

The app opens in English and the phone is in Portuguese.

The first time it follows the device's language. Tap the "EN" beside the globe, in the header, and choose Português: your choice wins from then on.

Glossary

biblioteca.txt

The file where the catalogue lives. Plain text, one book per line, fields separated by tabs. It is the same file on all four platforms.

biblioteca.dat

The file of cover photos, beside the .txt. Android reads it; it is written by the Mac and iPhone apps.

Linking the folder

Telling the app which folder your biblioteca.txt is in — or will be in. Done once, the app remembers.

Root

The top level of a storage: "My Drive", the phone's memory. Android does not let you pick roots in the folder picker; you have to go into a subfolder.

ISBN

The 10- or 13-digit number that identifies an edition. It is what the barcode on the back cover carries, and what the app uses to look the book up.

Where the copy is

Where your book physically is — the shelf, the box, the house of whoever borrowed it. Search looks in this field too.

Reading group

A mark for books discussed in a group. It works as a filter in search.

References

- The app's page: https://ruggierow.github.io/biblioteca/
- Manuals for the other platforms (Mac, Windows and iPhone) on the same page.
- The biblioteca.txt format is described in comum/formato-tsv.md, in the project repository.